

Session 10: The Origin of the Bible From a Historical Perspective

Key Takeaways

- The Bible’s divinity and authority doesn’t negate the human processes that brought it into existence.
- The Hebrew Bible is a collection of collections made up of preexisting textual materials from different periods of Israel’s history and literature.
- We find clues throughout the Hebrew Bible that reveal how each book is an organized collection of preexisting materials that have been brought into, and play a new function within, a new composition.

The Origins of the Bible From a Historical Perspective

The written origins of the Bible are also illuminated through historical research into the technology of writing, text production, and transmission in ancient Israel and their surrounding cultures.

The Hebrew Bible is a collection of collections made up of textual materials from all periods of Israel’s history, religion, and literature. Ancient Israelite tradition literature came into existence through a multistep process that is still discernible by looking at literary evidence within the texts themselves.

Events ↘	• The life of Abraham, the exodus, the wilderness wanderings, settlement in the land of Canaan, etc.		
	Oral Traditions ↘	• The family history of Abraham’s ancestors, the wilderness wanderings • Early songs: Exodus 15, Judges 5, Psalm 29, etc.	
		Early Written Traditions ↘	• “This is the scroll of the generations of humanity” (Gen. 5:1) • “The scroll of Jashar” (Josh. 10:13; 2 Sam. 1:18) • “The scroll of the wars of Yahweh” (Num. 21:14)
The Origins of the Bible From a Historical Perspective. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).			

	Early Collections of Written Traditions ↘	• “The scroll of the deeds of the kings of Israel” (1 Kgs. 14:19, 29, etc.) • “The commentary of the scroll of the kings” (2 Chron. 24:27)
	Proto-Editions of Biblical Books ↘	• “The proverbs of Solomon that the men of Hezekiah compiled” (Prov. 25:1) • “The prayers of David son of Jesse are ended” (Ps. 72:20) • The “Mosaic” Torah (Exod. 21-23 and Deut. 12-26) • First edition of Jeremiah (Jer. 36)
		TaNaK Editions of Biblical Books
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The Scribal Origins of the Bible

We have an abundance of evidence about the status and practice of the professional scribe in the ancient Near East. For recent scholarship, see the following:

- John Walton and Brent Sandy, [The Lost World of Scripture](#)
- William Schniedewind, [How the Bible Became a Book](#)
- Karel van der Toorn, [Scribal Culture and the Making of the Hebrew Bible](#)

Scribes were a professional class in the ancient world who handled and created texts in a variety of ways.

- They created new texts that were commissioned such as letters, receipts, and diplomatic correspondence.
- They preserved the cherished traditional literature of their culture such as poems, epic stories, ritual texts, and cultural mythology.
- They preserved the official records of their political and religious institution such as the annals of the king’s wars and activities.

Reflection Question

Summarize what you think is most important for people to understand about the compositional process of the Bible or about the nature of the Bible as human and divine.